(b) Germany in the post-War

The factors which led to the eventual triumph of Fascism in Germany were many. First was the sense of humiliation arising from the defeat in War. Between 1871 and 1914 Germany had risen to dizzy heights of economic, political and cultural accomplishments. Germany's universities, its science, philosophy and music were known all over the world. Germany had surpassed even Britain and the US in several fields of industrial production. Then came the crushing defeat in the First World War. The German people were demoralised. The reparations and other clauses in the Treaty of Versailles caused acute discontent and hardship. This was utilised by reactionary forces to spread the idea that Socialists and Jews in the government had let down the nation, and had even caused the Germany's defeat.

Germany had always been a military state. The army was the symbol not merely of security but of national greatness. Therefore Germany's defeat and humiliation at the end of World War I caused a deep shock to Germans. The Great Depression further deepened their frustration and prompted them to turn against the Republican government.

Germany in the 1920s

Germany after the First World War formed democratic governments through coalition of political parties. Socialist Ebert led the government from 1919-1925 and later. Stresemann as one associated with liberal democrats conducted the governance of the country until 1929. This period, until the rise of the Nazis in 1933, is called the Weimar Republic.



Hitler

The ordinary German citizen in these years was concerned himself only with the problems of everyday life in an impoverished country under the burden of reparations. The occupation of the Ruhr by the French in 1923 infuriated the workers to organise strikes in protest. It provided an opportunity to certain underground movements to thrive. There was already one in Berlin under Ludendorff, who had organised the former soldiers against the Republican government. There was another in Munich, a former corporal. He was Adolf Hitler, the leader of the National Socialist German Workers' Party.

Evolution of German Fascism

During World War I, Hitler served in the Bavarian army. Hitler had developed an innate hatred against Jews and Marxists. A gifted speaker, he could whip up the passion of the audience. In 1923 Hitler abortively attempted to capture power in Bavaria. His premature launch of the National Revolution on the outskirts of Munich landed him in prison. During his time in prison he worked on *Mein Kampf* (My Struggle), an autobiographical book containing his political ideas.

In 1929 two things occurred which exposed the weakness of the German government. Stresemann died and there was a political vacuum. The failure of the New York Stock Market triggering economic depression prompted the US to foreclose its German loans. By 1931 the world economic depression had gripped an already feeble Germany. In the Presidential election of 1932 the Communist Party polled about 60,00,000 votes. Alarmed capitalists and property owners tilted towards supporting fascism. Hitler exploited this opportunity to usurp powers.

The Third Reich

Republican government in Germany fell, as the Communists refused to collaborate with the Social Democrats. Thereupon industrialists, bankers and Junkers prevailed upon President Von Hindenburg to designate Hitler as Chancellor in 1933 in the hope that they could control him. The Nazi state of Hitler, known as the Third Reich, brought an end to the parliamentary democracy established in Germany after the First World War.

Hitler replaced the flag of the Weimar republic by the swastika banners of National Socialism. Germany was converted into a highly centralised state. All political parties except the

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